

Figure 4. Kandariya Mahadev Temple

Generally speaking, the earlier Chandelas were Vaishnavites, the later ones Shaivites. Ten of the extant temples at Khajuraho are dedicated to Vishnu and his incarnations (Varaha, Vamana, Vaikunth), eight to Shiva, one each to Surya and sixty-four yoginis (i.e., Tantric goddesses and assistants to Shakti or Kali) and five to Jain tirthankars. Buddhism is conspicuously missing, save for a solitary image of the Buddha. Other gods, heroes, sages and religious beings that appear often include Rama, Sita, Krishna, Balarama, Parvati, Lakshmi, Saraswati, Brahma, Narasimha, Ardhnarisvara, Matsya, Nandi, Bhairava, Sadasiva, Hanuman, Parasurama, Kalki, Kama, Rati, Ganesh, Indra, Agni, Kuber, Vishvakarma, Tantric goddesses like Chamunda, Matrikas and others, as well as many lesser divine beings in supporting roles—incarnations or animal vehicles.

In their temple designs, the architects sought to integrate a complex cosmic vision with ideas of a sacred geography—the temple as the cosmos